

who became England's ruling class, its gentry, and its rich. They even gave England a new language, Latinized English, which is still used to write legal documents and school term papers.

Monaco was taken by force by an armed band of Genoese led by Francois Grimaldi in 1297. This was the beginning of the dynasty that still runs the place. It was greatly enriched after Charles Grimaldi sacked Southampton in 1338, bringing the booty back to Monaco.

Once the social and political order of Europe was more or less settled, with kings and queens firmly in charge, it was very hard for an upstart to make much headway. Roles were fixed, so they believed, by God. A man who was born a field hand was meant to stay put. An occasional gifted student might make his way to the court and thereby gain a favor. But for most ambitious people, there were few opportunities to accumulate wealth.

The discovery of the New World opened up opportunities. For the conquistadors, these opportunities were very similar to the opportunities afforded to the Germanic tribes that had invaded Western Europe 1,000 years earlier. It was an opportunity for theft. They could gain vast fortunes and vast domains by stealing from the local people.

In North America, there was less to steal and more to take. The native peoples had little portable wealth and loose claims to the land they lived on. Settlers could take as much as they wanted and then sell it on, at low prices, to new arrivals. An ambitious land speculator, such as George Washington, could make a family fortune for himself.

But the really big boost in wealth accumulation began with the Industrial Revolution. Then, it was possible to create a fortune without committing a sin or a crime. Capitalism is civilized, in the sense that it depends on willing exchanges of labor and property. There is no theft involved. And it encourages ownership of assets other than land. For the first time, people could own shares in businesses that they did not personally control. And by pooling their resources, people could undertake projects on a much larger scale, which brought even more wealth creation.

Capitalism is what made most modern family fortunes possible. And it continues to be the source of most family wealth. Gone are most of the fortunes from the land grabs of bygone centuries. Today's wealth is based on trade, commerce, production, financing and the other moving parts of a